

S-Media Butterfly, PQI Joy Tone U800 and Umax Vega MP3 Players

With the sudden spurt in the number of MP3 players launched by various brands, buyers now have the luxury to choose from a wide range of players, based on hard drive and flash memory. We compared three flash memory based MP3 players that are portable, look good and can carry enough songs to keep you charged for at



S-Media Butterfly

least two hours. All three have a storage capacity of 128 MB.

The best thing about flash-based MP3 players is that they are small and light. PQI Joy Tone, an MP3/WMA player, is the lightest of the three, and hence, the most portable. Blood red in colour, it sports the traditional USB stick look, with the only difference being the LCD panel on the front face.

Second to Joy Tone is Umax Vega, which has a rather unusual square shape. It also has an inbuilt SD/MMC card reader. The small LCD panel on the front face shows information, such as track names, equaliser modes, and duration of the tracks in seconds—all tiny, but readable, with a backdrop of tidy animation.

Graph Features (out of 50 - Higher the better)	
PQI Joy Tone	28.5
S-media Butterfly	28.5
Umax Vega	25

In contrast, the Butterfly from S-Media is way too bulky. It sports the typical flip design of a cell phone, but opens to almost 340 degrees—a standard cell phone flip opens to about 120 to 150 degrees. Opening the flips completely, reveals the USB connector and the two tiny speakers. Both the earphones and speakers provide output simultaneously, a feature that can result in lower battery life. Ideally, the speakers should switch off automatically when earphones are plugged in.

The Butterfly also has a Line-In to record directly from the PC—a special feature missing in the other two contenders. All three players have the USB 1.1 interface and are detected in Windows XP without drivers. The Umax Vega draws power from an AAA battery, while the Joy Tone and Butterfly have in-built batteries that are charged when connected to the PC. So you'll actually be charging the device while you're transferring data to it.

The Joy Tone and Umax Vega are bundled with headphones that are attached to the neck strap. Encasing the wires in the

neck strap, eliminates the chances of damaging them. The earphones of the Joy Tone also double up as a wired remote, with an FM scan and a reset button.

All three players returned nearly the same results in the audio quality test. The scores were average in the test tracks—a mix of Hindi, English and Bass tracks at 75 per cent volume. However, once the volume level was turned up, the noise and distortion, especially with high frequency sounds, were bad. All three players are bundled with poor quality earphones. You'll have to buy a better set of headphones to enjoy the sound output. The FM reception is clear when outdoors, but inside buildings, or when away from windows, all three players fail to receive properly.

The voice recording feature is decent. The recorder isn't very useful outdoors, since background noise is way too prominent while recording.

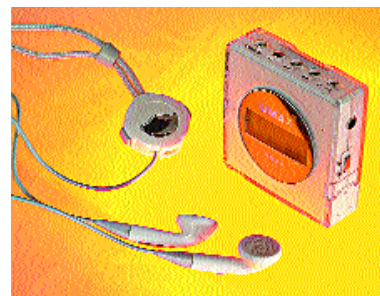
Priced at Rs 49,999, the Joy Tone is reasonable for a flash memory-based player that records, and has an FM radio. The Umax Vega



PQI Joy Tone U800

is priced higher at Rs 7,000, with the additional feature of a card reader. The Butterfly is bulky, but has the advantage of an external speaker, though at the cost of using more power.

we decided that the Joy Tone was the best amongst these, as far as music goes. If you need more storage, the Umax will come in handy, since the card reader can store many more tracks.



Umax Vega

Umax Vega		C+
Performance	▲▲▲▲▲	
Features	▲▲▲▲▲	
Build quality	▲▲▲▲▲	
Value for money	▲▲▲▲▲	

SPECIFICATIONS

128MB capacity, Card reader, MP3 and WMA playback, FM radio, Voice recorder, USB flash drive, 1 AAA battery

Price: Rs 7,000
Contacts: Neoteric Informatique
Phone: 022-24172600
E-mail: sales@neoteric-co.in
Web site: www.umax.com

PQI Joy Tone U800		B-
Performance	▲▲▲▲▲	
Features	▲▲▲▲▲	
Build quality	▲▲▲▲▲	
Value for money	▲▲▲▲▲	

SPECIFICATIONS

128MB capacity; MP3/WMA playback; FM radio; Voice recording; USB flash drive; Built-in Li-ion battery;

Price: Rs 4,999
Contacts: Shree Sagarmatha Distributors Pvt Ltd
Phone: 011-26428541
E-mail: sagarmatha_dlh@bol.net.in
Web site: www.pqi.com.tw

S-Media Butterfly		B+
Performance	▲▲▲▲▲	
Features	▲▲▲▲▲	
Build quality	▲▲▲▲▲	
Value for money	▲▲▲▲▲	

SPECIFICATIONS

128MB capacity, MP3 and WMA playback, FM radio, Voice recorder, USB flash drive, Built-in Li-ion battery, USB interface

Price: Rs 7,990 +taxes
Contacts: Xserve India Pvt. Ltd
Phone: 080-51131001
E-mail: info@xserves.com
Web site: www.s-media.com